Life, the Universe, and Everything 2026 Midterm with Answers

Please note: The order of questions, as well as the order of options, was randomized for each student. Therefore, the sequence shown below may differ from the order you encountered during the exam.

Question #: 1

[6 points]

P1. If cultural relativism is true, moral progress is impossible.
P2. It is not the case that moral progress is impossible.
C. Therefore, cultural relativism is not true.

Samantha, who is a cultural relativist, responds to this argument by distinguishing between a society's common practices and ideals and claiming that a society may fail to live up to its own ideals sometimes.

Which of the following is/are true? Assume that Samantha accurately understands validity and soundness.

Select all correct answers (there may or may not be more than one correct answer, and there is at least one correct answer). No partial credit will be given.

✓A. Samantha is denying P1.
B. Samantha is denying P2.
C. Samantha thinks that the argument is invalid.
✓D. Samantha thinks that the argument is unsound.

Answer: A and D. No partial credit.

A is true because what Samantha is claiming is that there is a way in which cultural relativists can make sense of moral improvement—when a society failed to live up to its own ideals in the past but succeeds in doing so now, that counts as moral improvement. So, she is denying P1, claiming that even if cultural relativism is true, moral progress is not impossible. Also see the relevant lecture slide below.

Possible responses to Rachels' arguments from cultural relativists

- Rachels' arguments that cultural relativism is false have the following structure.

~~P1. If cultural relativism is true, [insert a counterintuitive implication of cultural relativism].~~

P2. It is **not the case** that [ ].

C. Therefore, cultural relativism is **not** true.

- He mentions three such implications/consequences.

1. The customs of other societies are never morally inferior to our own.
2. We could decide whether actions are right or wrong just by consulting the standards of our society.
3. Moral progress is impossible.

Second, cultural relativists might deny P1, by distinguishing between a society's common practices and **ideals (fundamental standards)** and claiming that only the latter determines what is right or wrong in the society. Since members of a society may not know the society's ideals or may fail to live up to them, even on cultural relativism, one society can be morally inferior to another (if the first fails to live up to its own ideals), one cannot necessarily decide whether actions are right or wrong just by consulting the standards of our society (because these standards might not be the ideals), and moral progress is possible in some sense.

B is false because Samantha thinks that moral progress is possible (in the way described above). So, she thinks P2 is true.

C is false because Samantha accurately understands validity and soundness, and the argument is valid.

D is true because Samantha accurately understands validity and soundness, and she thinks P1 is false (a sound argument is valid and <u>has all true premises</u>).

Question #: 2

[5 points]

Is the following statement true or false?

A valid argument with all false premises can have a true conclusion.

✓A. True
B. False

Answer: True

As indicated in the slide below, a valid argument is an argument such that if the premises are all *true*, the conclusion must be true as well. Note that this definition of validity doesn't say anything about what happens to the conclusion if the premises are all *false*. So, in such cases, the conclusion could be true, or it could be false.

We've in fact seen an example of a valid argument with all false premises having a true conclusion. See the Jungkook argument in the slide below. P1 and P2 are false, but the conclusion is true.

- A **sound** argument is a **valid** argument whose **premises are all true.**

  Soundness = (1) validity + (2) all premises being true.

  Both conditions need to be met for an argument to be sound.

- A **valid** argument:

  Its premises and conclusion are connected in such a way that…

  if the premises are all true, the conclusion must be true as well.

  In other words, the conclusion follows from the premises.

  The premises, if all true, 100% guarantee the truth of the conclusion.

  (It doesn't matter whether the premises are actually true.)

  How to check whether an argument is valid:

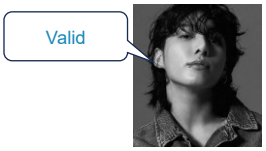
  Assume that all the premises are true and think about whether it is possible for the conclusion to be false.

  If yes, invalid. If no, valid.

  E.g.) P1. All philosophers are men.

  P2. Jungkook is a philosopher. Valid or invalid?

  C. Jungkook is a man.



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Question #: 3

[6 points]

Chris is presented with an argument with two premises, P1 and P2, and a conclusion. He thinks the argument is invalid. Showing which of the following would be enough for him to prove that it is invalid?

A. P1 is false.
B. P2 is false.
C. The conclusion is false.
D. At least one of the two premises is false.
E. A and B
F. A, B, and C
✓G. None of the above

Answer: G

As written in the slide above, a valid argument is an argument whose premises and conclusion are connected in such a way that if the premises are all true, the conclusion must be true as well. An invalid argument, then, is an argument whose premises and conclusion are not connected in that way—even if

the premises are all true, the conclusion can be false. So, in order to show that an argument is invalid, you need to show that it is possible for the premises to be all true while at the same time the conclusion is false. None of A-F is enough to show this.

Note that this is the same idea as the following part of the slide above: "How to check whether an argument is valid: **Assume** that all the premises are true and think about whether it is possible for the conclusion to be false. If yes, invalid."

Another way to solve this question is to think about whether each of the options is enough to make an argument invalid.
A is not enough because a valid argument can have a false premise.
B is not enough for the same reason why A is not enough.
C is not enough because a valid argument can have a false conclusion.
D is not enough because a valid argument can have at least one false premise.
E is not enough because a valid argument can have all false premises.
F is not enough because a valid argument can have all false premises and a false conclusion.

Question #: 4

[6 points]

P1. If cultural relativism is true, then it is morally wrong for anyone in any culture to criticize another culture.
P2. It is morally wrong for anyone in any culture to criticize another culture.
C. Therefore, cultural relativism is true.

Which of the following is/are true?

Select all correct answers (there may or may not be more than one correct answer, and there is at least one correct answer). Partial credit may be awarded. Incorrect choices will be penalized.

A. The argument is sound.
B. The argument is valid.
C. P1 is true.
D. If you think P2 is true, you must also think that the conclusion is true.
✓E. James Rachels would say that the argument is unsound.

Answer: E

Partial credit is given as follows.
If you didn't choose E at all (e.g., you chose A and C) → 0 points

If you chose E but also chose some other option(s) (e.g., you chose A and E) → 6 points minus 1.5 points per incorrect choice. For example, if you chose A and E, you get 6−1.5 = 4.5 points. If you chose C, D, and E, then you get 6−(1.5*2) = 3 points. Note: The minimum score for any question is 0; you cannot receive negative points.

The argument has the following form:
P1. If A, then B.
P2. B
C. Therefore, A.
As we learned in class, any argument with this form is invalid. And an invalid argument is unsound. Therefore, Options A and B are false.

C is false because P1 is false. It is not the case that if cultural relativism is true, then it is morally wrong for anyone in any culture to criticize another culture. If cultural relativism is true, the moral code of a society determines what is right or wrong within that society. This means that criticizing another culture is morally wrong in a society whose moral code says that it is wrong, and criticizing another culture is not morally wrong in a society whose moral code says that it is not wrong.

D is false. If you think that it is morally wrong for anyone in any culture to criticize another culture, you don't need to think that cultural relativism is true. In fact, you more naturally think that cultural relativism is false because you think that there is a universal moral truth (namely that it is wrong to criticize another culture).

E is true. The argument is invalid and therefore unsound, which James Rachels would correctly point out.

Question #: 5

[6 points]

Which of the following is/are true about this argument?

P1. If a hedonist can accept that knowledge is instrumentally good, then a desire theorist can accept that knowledge is instrumentally good.
P2. A desire theorist can accept that knowledge is instrumentally good.
C. Therefore, a hedonist can accept that knowledge is instrumentally good.

Select all correct answers (there may or may not be more than one correct answer, and there is at least one correct answer). No partial credit will be given.

A. The argument is valid.
✓B. The argument is invalid.
C. The argument is sound.

✓D. The argument is unsound.

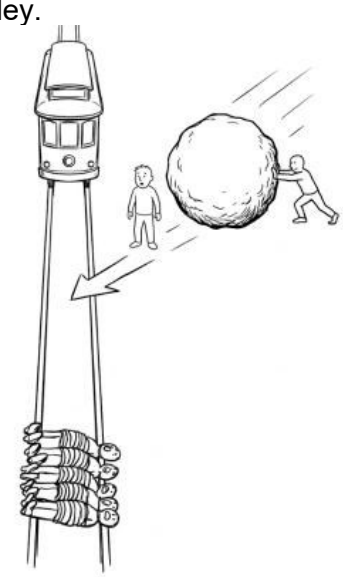
Answer: B and D. No partial credit.

The argument has the following form:
P1. If A, then B.
P2. B
C. Therefore, A.
As we learned in class, any argument with this form is invalid. And an invalid argument is unsound.

Question #: 6

[6 points]

Suppose a trolley is heading toward five people. You cannot divert the trolley onto another track. The only way to save the five is to push a large, heavy boulder onto the track to stop the trolley (the boulder would remain in its place unless you push it). Unfortunately, an innocent bystander is standing next to the boulder in a position where the boulder will crush them to death as it rolls onto the track. You cannot warn the bystander in time, and they cannot move away before the boulder hits them. Assume the boulder would stop the trolley even if the bystander were not there; the bystander's body plays no role in stopping the trolley.

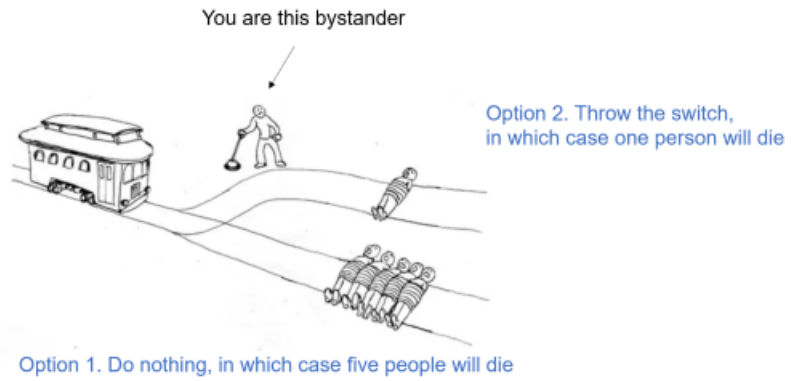


Based on Thomson's view in "Turning the Trolley", what would she say about this case?

Select all correct answers (there may or may not be more than one correct answer, and there is at least one correct answer). Partial credit may be awarded. Incorrect choices will be penalized.

In the options, Bystander refers to the following case:

< Bystander >



A. Thomson would say that pushing the boulder is morally permissible because you are not treating the innocent bystander as a means.
B. Thomson would say that pushing the boulder is morally permissible because although the means you use is drastic, this fact is morally irrelevant.
✓C. Thomson would say that pushing the boulder is morally wrong because doing so counts as killing the innocent bystander, whereas not pushing it counts as letting the five people die.
✓D. Thomson would say that pushing the boulder has the same moral status as throwing the switch in Bystander (that is, either both are permissible or both are wrong).

Answer: C and D.

Partial credit is given as follows: 6 points - 3 points per incorrect choice, including not choosing a correct option. For example, if you chose C only, you get 6–3=3 points because you made one incorrect choice (not choosing D). If you chose B and C, you get 6–3*2=0 points because you made two incorrect choices (not choosing D and choosing B). Note: The minimum score for any question is 0; you cannot receive negative points.

Let's first recall what Thomson says in "Turning the Trolley". She claims that throwing the switch in Bystander is morally wrong because it counts as killing the one person on the side track, whereas not throwing the switch counts as letting the five people die, and because killing is morally worse than letting die.

Now, pushing the boulder has the same structure as Bystander—your options are killing one person (pushing the boulder) and letting five people die (not pushing the boulder). So, Thomson would say that pushing the boulder is morally wrong. (You can easily infer that Thomson would consider pushing the boulder as killing based on the fact that she considers throwing the switch in Bystander as killing. If anything, pushing the boulder is more killing-like.)

With this, let's now look at the options.

A is false because Thomson would not say that pushing the boulder is morally permissible. (She also doesn't talk about treating a person as a means. That's Kant's view.)

B is false because Thomson would not say that pushing the boulder is morally permissible. She indeed would say that the means being drastic is morally irrelevant, but that doesn't make pushing the boulder morally permissible.

C is true, as I just explained above.

D is true. As I explained above, Thomson would say that pushing the boulder and throwing the switch in Bystander are both morally wrong.

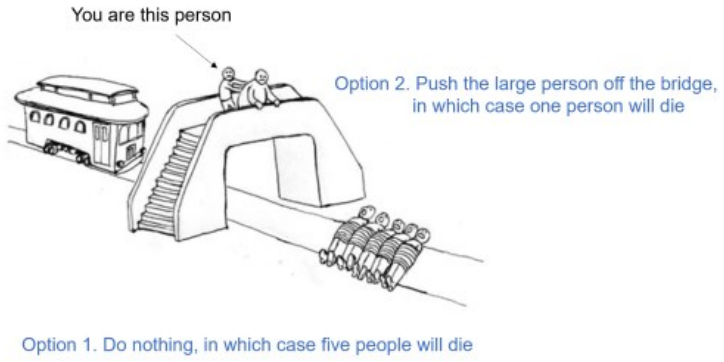
Question #: 7

[6 points]

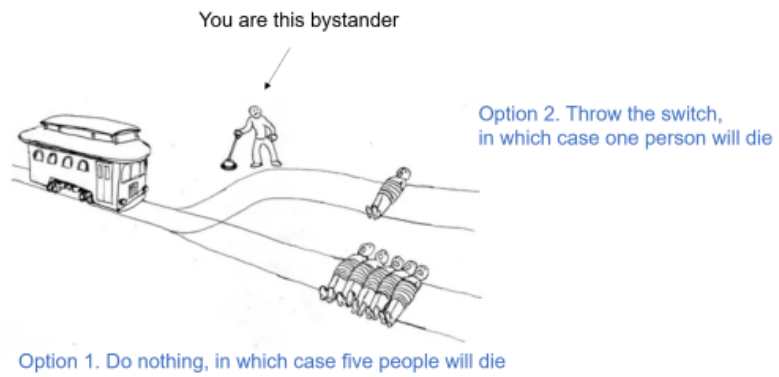
Is the following statement true or false?
Thomson's view (as expressed in "Turning the Trolley") and classic utilitarianism both treat the difference between Bridge and Bystander as morally irrelevant.

Bridge and Bystander refer to the following cases:

< Bridge >



< Bystander >



✓A. True
B. False

Answer: True

As indicated in the following slide, Thomson thinks the difference between Bridge and Bystander—how drastic the means used is—morally irrelevant. According to her view, in both cases, Option 2 counts as killing while Option 1 counts as letting die, so Option 2 is wrong and Option 1 is permissible.

Why, then, do many people think that it is morally *permissible* for the bystander to throw the switch?

J. J. Thomson
(1929-2020)

It is because the means used in Bystander (i.e., merely turning a trolley or throwing a switch) is not drastic, compared to the means used in Bridge (i.e., pushing a person off the bridge).

But this fact about the means is not morally relevant.

According to classic utilitarianism, only consequences matter. The difference between Bridge and Bystander is not a matter of consequences, so it is morally irrelevant on classic utilitarianism. Of course, classic utilitarians would say that both in Bridge and Bystander, Option 2 is permissible and Option 1 is wrong, which is different from Thomson's verdict. But both classic utilitarians and Thomson think the difference between Bridge and Bystander does not matter morally, and that's what the question is about.

Question #: 8

[6 points]

Below is a passage from Thomson's "Turning the Trolley".

"Consider a case often called Transplant: I am a surgeon, and can save my five patients who are in need of organs only by cutting up one healthy bystander—a bystander who has not volunteered—and distributing his organs among the five."

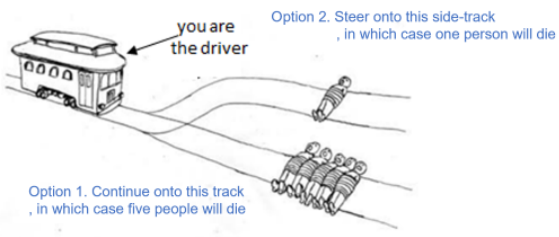
Assume that if the surgeon cuts up the bystander and performs the transplants, the bystander will die and the five patients will survive; if the surgeon does not, the five patients will die of their illnesses (there are no other organ donors) and the bystander will survive.

Which of the following is/are true?

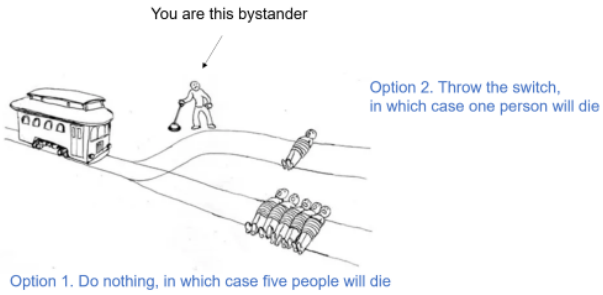
Select all correct answers (there may or may not be more than one correct answer, and there is at least one correct answer). Partial credit may be awarded. Incorrect choices will be penalized.

In the options below, Driver and Bystander refer to the following cases:

< Driver >



< Bystander >



A. Thomson brings up Transplant to show that there is no morally relevant difference between Driver and Bystander.

✓B. If the surgeon cuts up the healthy bystander to save the five patients, the surgeon is treating the bystander as a means.

C. Kant would say that it is morally wrong for the surgeon to cut up the healthy bystander because

Kant claims that treating a person as a means is always morally wrong.

✓D. Philippa Foot would say that it is morally wrong for the surgeon to cut up the healthy bystander to save the five patients.

Answer: B and D.
Partial credit is given as follows: 6 points - 3 points per incorrect choice, including not choosing a correct option. For example, if you chose B only, you get 6–3=3 points because you made one incorrect choice (not choosing D). If you chose B and C, you get 6–3*2=0 points because you made two incorrect choices (not choosing D and choosing C). Note: The minimum score for any question is 0; you cannot receive negative points.

A is false because Thomson thinks that there is a morally relevant difference between Driver and Bystander. In Driver, both Options 1 and 2 count as killing, whereas in Bystander, Option 1 counts as letting die and Option 2 counts as killing. Hence, Option 2 is permissible in Driver but wrong in Bystander.

B is true because if the surgeon cuts the bystander to save the five patients, the bystander's involvement is part of the route by which the surgeon's plan succeeds. In other words, the surgeon cannot achieve their goal if the bystander disappears right before the surgeon performs the action.

C is false because, as I emphasized in class, Kant does not claim that treating a person as a means is always morally wrong. What he thinks is always morally wrong is treating a person merely as a means.

D is true because according to Foot, killing is worse than letting die, and cutting up the bystander counts as killing the bystander, whereas not doing so counts as letting the five patients die.

Question #: 9

[6 points]

Which of the following combinations is/are possible?

Interpret "killing" in Thomson's sense and "treating a person as a means" in the Kantian sense discussed in class.

Select all correct answers (there may or may not be more than one correct answer, and there is at least one correct answer). Partial credit may be awarded. Incorrect choices will be penalized.

✓A. Killing a person while treating them as a means

✓B. Killing a person without treating them as a means

✓C. Treating a person as a means without killing them

✓D. Not treating a person as a means while not killing them

Answer: A, B, C, D.

Partial credit is given as follows: 6 points – 1.5 points per incorrect choice, including not choosing a correct option. For example, if you chose A and B only, you get 6–3=3 points because you made two incorrect choices (not choosing C and not choosing D). Note: The minimum score for any question is 0; you cannot receive negative points.

A is true because killing a person while treating them as a means is possible. Pushing the large person in Bridge is such a case.

B is true because killing a person without treating them as a means is possible. Throwing the switch in Bystander is such a case.

C is true because treating a person as a means without killing them is possible. Permissible cases of treating a person as a means that were discussed in class, including taking a bus and thereby using a bus driver to go to a place, can be such cases. Even morally impermissible cases of treating a person as a means (e.g., lying to someone for your own self-interest) can also fit this category, provided you do not kill the person.

D is true because not treating a person as a means while not killing them is possible. This usually happens when you're not interacting with another person in any way.

Question #: 10

[5 points]

Is the following statement true or false?

If an action is morally supererogatory, then it is morally permissible.

✓A. True
B. False

Answer: True

"If A, then B" means that A is a subset of B or, in other words, that whenever A is true, B is always true. And, as we learned in class, supererogatory actions are a subset of morally permissible actions.

Whenever an action is supererogatory—the action goes above and beyond one's moral duties—it is morally permissible (= not morally wrong).

Question #: 11

[6 points]

Below are two different versions of Singer's claim.

Strong version: we ought to be preventing as much suffering as we can without sacrificing something else of comparable moral importance.
Moderate version: we ought to be preventing as much suffering as we can without sacrificing something else of moral importance.

Which of the following statements accurately describe(s) differences between the strong and the moderate versions?

Select all correct answers (there may or may not be more than one correct answer, and there is at least one correct answer). Partial credit may be awarded. Incorrect choices will be penalized.

A. The strong version requires us to maximize total net happiness, while the moderate version only requires us to reduce suffering.
B. The strong version makes supererogatory actions impossible, while the moderate version makes supererogatory actions possible.
✓C. The strong version requires us to donate more money to charities than the moderate version does.
D. The strong version applies only to extreme poverty, while the moderate version applies to all forms of suffering.

Answer: C.

Partial credit is given as follows.
If you didn't choose C at all (e.g., you chose A and B) → 0 points.
If you chose C but also chose some other option(s) (e.g., you chose A and C) → 6 points minus 2 points per incorrect choice. For example, if you chose A and C, you get 6−2 = 4 points. If you chose A, C, and D then you get 6−(2*2) = 2 points. Note: The minimum score for any question is 0; you cannot receive negative points.

A is false. As the slide below indicates, even the strong version only concerns reducing suffering. You can also easily see that the description of the strong version included in the question only mentions suffering.

B is false. Both versions make supererogatory actions possible. For example, maximising total net happiness by making already happy people happier would count as supererogatory according to both versions because neither version requires this. Also see the slide below.

C is true. As we learned in class, according to the strong version, you should keep donating until we reach a similar level of suffering as the people we're helping (until we ourselves almost lack food to eat, if you're helping people suffering from lack of food). According to the moderate version, we can stop before reaching the point where you have to give up something important (e.g., your child's education) even if you're still much better off than the people you're helping.

D is false. As you can see from the descriptions of the two versions included in the question, both versions mention just "suffering". So both versions apply to all forms of suffering.

<Clarifications about Singer's view as it is expressed in this paper>

- Note that even the strong version only concerns reducing pain or suffering, not maximizing total net pleasure or happiness.
- So, if people in developing countries were already happy and did not suffer, even the strong version wouldn't require us to help them become happier even if that would maximize total net happiness.
- Thus, Singer, in the context of this paper, can allow that there are such things as supererogatory actions (e.g., maximizing total net happiness by making already happy people happier).
- Singer's claim, thus, is not that there are no such things as supererogatory actions, but that it is not a supererogatory action for us to help people in developing countries (without sacrificing something of (comparable) moral importance). This is morally required; It is wrong not to do so.

Question #: 12

[6 points]

Is the following argument valid or invalid?

P1. If Peter Singer's argument is sound, then it is morally wrong to buy a luxury car when there are people suffering from extreme poverty in developing countries.
P2. Peter Singer's argument is not sound.
C. Therefore, it is not morally wrong to buy a luxury car when there are people suffering from extreme poverty in developing countries.

A. Valid
✓B. Invalid

Answer: B

This argument has the following form:
P1. If A, then B.
P2. Not A.
C. Therefore, not B.

As we learned in class, any argument with this form is invalid.

Another way to explain why the argument is invalid is as follows: even if Peter Singer's argument is not sound, it could still be morally wrong to buy a luxury car for some other reason.

Question #: 13

[6 points]

You have only two available actions to choose from, with no other options. Below is the full information about how much pleasure and pain each action will generate. The actions will not generate any additional pleasure or pain beyond what is described.

Action 1 will generate 1 unit of pain (and 0 units of pleasure) per person for 100 people.
Action 2 will generate 150 units of pain (and 0 units of pleasure) for one person, and the other 99 people experience neither pleasure nor pain.

Assume that a unit of pleasure or pain is of the exact same amount and quality, regardless of who experiences it.

Which action is right according to classic utilitarianism (as understood in our course)?

✓A. Action 1
B. Action 2
C. Both actions
D. Neither action

Answer: A

According to classic utilitarianism, a right action is an action that maximizes total net pleasure or, equivalently, minimizes total net pain/suffering—in other words, an action that generates greatest total net pleasure (or least total net pain) among the available actions in the given situation. Action 1 will generate -100 units of total net pleasure (or 100 units of total net pain), and Action 2 will generate -150 units of total net pleasure (or 150 units of total net pain). So, Action 1 will generate greater total net

pleasure (and lesser total net pain) than Action 2 will, so Action 1 is the right action.

Also see the following slide, which mentions a similar case where all available actions generate only pain.

(Classic) Utilitarianism

- (Classic) Utilitarianism: a right action is an action that maximizes the good, with the good understood according to hedonism.
  → a right action is an action that maximizes total net pleasure or happiness

  total net pleasure = total pleasure the action produces to everyone affected by the action – total pain the action produces to everyone affected by the action

- E.g.,) There are two available actions in the situation:

  Action1 produces 0 units of pleasure and 5 units of pain = -5 units of pleasure (or 5 units of pain)
  Action2 produces 0 units of pleasure and 2 units of pain = -2 unit of pleasure (or 2 units of pain)
  → Action2 is the right action because it maximizes total net pleasure (or minimize total net pain)

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Question #: 14

[6 points]

You have only three available actions to choose from, with no other options. Below is the full information about how much pleasure and pain each action will generate. The actions will not generate any additional pleasure or pain beyond what is described.

Action 1 will generate 40 units of pleasure (and 0 units of pain) for one human being.
Action 2 will generate 5 units of pleasure (and 0 units of pain) per dog for 10 dogs.
Action 3 will generate 10 units of pleasure (and 0 units of pain) for one human being and 10 units of pain (and 0 units of pleasure) for one dog.

Assume that a unit of pleasure or pain is of the exact same amount and quality, regardless of which species experiences it.

Which of the following is/are true according to classic utilitarianism (as understood in our course)? Select all correct answers (there may or may not be more than one correct answer, and there is at least one correct answer). Partial credit may be awarded. Incorrect choices will be penalized.

A. Action 3 is morally neutral.
✓B. Action 2 is morally required.
C. Action 2 is supererogatory.
D. Action 1 is morally permissible.
E. Action 1 is morally neutral.

Answer: B

Partial credit is given as follows.
If you didn't choose B at all (e.g., you chose A and C) → 0 points
If you chose B but also chose some other option(s) (e.g., you chose A and B) → 6 points minus 1.5 points per incorrect choice. For example, if you chose A and B, you get 6−1.5 = 4.5 points. If you chose A, B, and C, then you get 6−(1.5*2) = 3 points. Note: The minimum score for any question is 0; you cannot receive negative points.

First of all, given the assumption that a unit of pleasure or pain is of the exact same amount and quality, regardless of which species experiences it, it does not matter whether a unit of pleasure or pain is experienced by a human being or a dog. All that matters, on classic utilitarianism, is the total net pleasure each action generates.

Action 1 generates 40 units of total net pleasure.
Action 2 generates 50 units of total net pleasure.
Action 3 generates 0 units of total net pleasure.

So, Action 2 maximizes total net pleasure, and, thus, is the right/morally permissible action according to classic utilitarianism. The other two actions generate less total net pleasure, so they are wrong according to classic utilitarianism. This means that the only permissible action is Action 2, so Action 2 is not just permissible but also required.

A is false because Action 3 is morally wrong rather than neutral. On classic utilitarianism, any action that fails to maximize total net happiness is wrong. That's why classic utilitarianism is demanding.

B is true, as I explained above.

C is false. Action 2 is morally required, and a supererogatory action is not morally required.

D is false because Action 1 is morally wrong as explained above.

E is false because Action 1 is morally wrong rather than neutral.

Question #: 15

[6 points]
The following case poses a problem for the desire theory.

- An oppressed slave whose only desire is to serve their master

Which of the following most accurately explains the reason why this case poses a problem for the desire theory?

A. Because, according to the desire theory, the slave does not know what is good for them.
✓B. Because, according to the desire theory, serving their master would be good for the slave.
C. Because the case shows that a desire can be satisfied without producing pleasure.
D. Because the case shows that whether a person's desire is satisfied depends on whether the person believes it is satisfied.

Answer: B.

According to the desire theory, the only thing that is non-instrumentally good is desire fulfilment. This means that whenever a desire is fulfilled, that is good for the person (unless it interferes with fulfilling other desires). So, on the desire theory, serving their master and thereby fulfilling their only desire is good for the slave. But it is intuitively not the case that serving their master is good for the slave. This is the reason why this case poses a problem for the desire theory. B most accurately describes the reason.

A is not accurate because it is not the case that according to the desire theory, the slave does not know what is good for them. Recall that, according to the desire theory, what is good for the slave is serving their master.

C is not accurate because, although a desire can indeed be satisfied without producing pleasure, that is not a problem for the desire theory. Nor is the slave case related to this point—the slave may well gain pleasure from serving their master.

D is not accurate because the case does not show that whether a person's desire is satisfied depends on whether the person believes it is satisfied. It is also false that whether a person's desire is satisfied depends on whether the person believes it is satisfied.

Question #: 16

[6 points]

Darren's mother is terminally ill with cancer, and her only desire is that Darren gets married before she

dies. Assume that there are only two possible cases:

Honesty: Darren tells his mother the truth: he is not married and will never get married. She remains unhappy, and then dies in a month.

Deception: Darren is not married and will never get married, but he lies to his mother that he got married and shows her fake wedding photos. She believes him, feels happy, and then dies in a month, never learning the truth. Although she lacks knowledge about her son's marital status, her life is more pleasant and less painful in Deception than in Honesty.

Eric, who is a philosopher, hears this story and says that Darren's mother's life has less non-instrumental value in Deception than in Honesty.

Given what Eric said, which of the following claims is Eric **unable** to accept?

Hint: you should first identify which of the three theories of non-instrumental value Eric endorses and then infer which claim(s) is/are not compatible with that theory (a claim being compatible with a theory means that it is possible for both the claim and the theory to be true at the same time).

Select all correct answers (there may or may not be more than one correct answer, and there is at least one correct answer). Partial credit may be awarded. Incorrect choices will be penalized.

A. The happiness Darren's mother feels in Deception can be instrumentally good.
B. We may not know exactly how valuable our life is.
✓C. What is good for a person depends only on what that person wants.
D. We should not plug into Nozick's experience machine for life.

Answer: C.

Partial credit is given as follows.
If you didn't choose C at all (e.g., you chose A) → 0 points
If you chose C but also chose some other option(s) (e.g., you chose A and C) → 6 points minus 2 points per incorrect choice. For example, if you chose A and C, you get 6−2 = 4 points. If you chose A, B, and C, then you get 6−(2*2) = 2 points. Note: The minimum score for any question is 0; you cannot receive negative points.

Let's first figure out which theory of non-instrumental value Eric endorses.

Eric is not a hedonist because a hedonist would say that Darren's mother's life has more non-instrumental value in Deception. The question clearly states that her life is more pleasant and less painful in Deception than in Honesty.

Eric is also not a desire theorist because a desire theorist would say that Darren's mother's life has the same non-instrumental value in Honesty and Deception. Her only desire is that Darren gets married before she dies and that desire is not satisfied in both scenarios.

Thus, Eric is an objective list theorist. Perhaps he thinks knowledge, among other things, is non-

instrumentally valuable and that is why he thinks that Darren's mother's life is less non-instrumentally valuable in Deception, where she lacks knowledge about her son's marital status.

We can now think about which option(s) an objective list theorist is unable to accept.

An objective list theorist can accept A because objective list theories are theories about *non-instrumental* value. So, the theories are compatible with the claim that her happiness is *instrumentally* good, even if happiness isn't non-instrumentally good. Perhaps Darren's mother's happiness helps her to make some small achievement (e.g., finishing reading a book) before she dies in Deception, but the value of the achievement is much less than the value of knowledge she has in Honesty, in which case her life has less non-instrumental value in Deception.

An objective list theorist can accept B because we may not know what things are objectively valuable and/or whether we have those objectively valuable things. Darren's mother in Deception is such a case—she thinks she has the knowledge about her son's marital status but she does not.

An objective list theorist cannot accept C. Recall how objective list theories are described in the lecture slides: "there are things that are objectively non-instrumentally good for a person. So, whether that person desires them or not doesn't matter". C describes the desire theory.

An objective list theorist can accept D. According to objective list theories, there are things other than pleasure that are non-instrumentally valuable, so we have reason not to plug into the experience machine for life.

Question #: 17

[6 points]

Which of the following is the best way to turn Nozick's "The Experience Machine" into an argument (that is, premise–conclusion) form?

"Best" means:
(1) it is **closest**, among the options, to what Nozick says in the reading and to how Moonyoung interprets him; and
(2) it makes the argument **valid**.

✓A. P1. If nothing matters to us besides how our lives feel from the inside, then we would choose to plug into an experience machine for life.

P2. We would not choose to plug into the experience machine for life.

C. Therefore, it is not the case that nothing matters to us besides how our lives feel from the inside.

B. P1. If we would choose to plug into an experience machine for life, then nothing matters to us besides how our lives feel from the inside.

P2. We would not choose to plug into an experience machine for life

C. Therefore, it is not the case that nothing matters to us besides how our lives feel from the inside.

C. P1. If it matters to us how our lives feel from the inside, then we would choose to plug into an experience machine for life.

P2. We would not choose to plug into the experience machine for life.

C. Therefore, it does not matter to us how our lives feel from the inside.

D. P1. If we would not choose to plug into an experience machine for life, then it does not matter to us how our lives feel from the inside.

P2. We would not choose to plug into an experience machine for life

C. Therefore, it does not matter to us how our lives feel from the inside.

Answer: A

Let's first recall what should be the conclusion. As indicated in the slide below, what Nozick is trying to show is that experience/pleasure isn't the only thing that matters to us (other things matter, too). He is not claiming that experience/pleasure doesn't matter to us. (One of the practice questions was also about this point.)

So, the more accurate conclusion of the argument is "it is not the case that nothing matters to us besides how our lives feel from the inside", rather than "it does not matter to us how our lives feel from the inside." This means that Options C and D are incorrect.

Let's look at Options A and B now.

Option A has the following form:

P1. If A, then B.
P2. Not B.
C. Not A.

Any argument with this form is valid.

Option B has the following form:

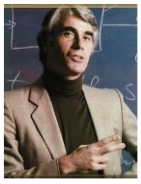
P1. If A, then B.
P2. Not A
C. Not B.

Any argument with this form is invalid.

So, only Option A is valid and accurate.

The Experience Machine

- Nozick's points seem to be as follows.
  - Most people would not plug into the experience machine for life, even though they would have more pleasure that way.
  - This counts against hedonism because if hedonism is true, which means pleasure is the only thing that is non-instrumentally good, there is no reason not to plug into the experience machine.
  - Our hesitation suggests that we think there are other things than pleasure that are non-instrumentally good.



Robert Nozick
(1938 – 2002)

"We learn that something matters to us in addition to experience [which includes pleasure] by imagining an experience machine and then realizing that we would not use it." (p.265)

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